

The Royal Pavilion

In the 1780s, England's Prince George rented a lodging house in Brighton, then a fishing village. He hired architect Henry Holland (1745–1806) to extend the house into a modest villa and, fascinated by Eastern designs, furnished and decorated it lavishly with imported Chinese furniture and wallpapers.

In 1815, by now Prince Regent, George commissioned John Nash to rebuild his villa and convert it into a magnificent Oriental-style palace. With William Porden (c.1755–1822) and Humphry Repton (1752–1818) working on aspects of it, it became an eclectic blend of Indian and Chinese influences, although Nash remained the chief architect. By 1821, the building was complete, with picturesque turban domes, minarets, moulded plaster and copper palm-leaf decorations. The domes were covered in sheet iron and the sumptuous hall was based on an illustration of one at Allahabad in India. In 1820, Frederick Crace (1779–1859) and Robert Jones (dates unknown) were employed to create the exotic Chinese-style interior decoration.

